

Netbook or notebook?

According to the NPD Group, 60 per cent of consumers who purchased a netbook instead of a notebook did not know the difference between the two

Nokia netbooks

Intel and Nokia have announced a partnership and are supposedly working on a netbook

netbook that comes with a non-removable lithium-polymer battery; just like the Macbook Air or the newer Macbook Pros. This could prove to be a limitation for those who like to carry spare batteries along with their portables. To achieve the streamlined design, Asus has neatly covered all the ports, thus protecting them from dust.

Opening this baby reveals the typical 10-inch screen with a web cam atop. We felt that the screen lacked the brightness that most of the other brands gave. We wouldn't really call this a deal-breaker though. The keyboard has large QWERTY keys that are good to type on. While trying to fit such large keys, the Up-Down, arrow and top-row function keys are shrunk considerably. We would have appreciated if at least the Up-Down keys were a little bigger. The touch-pad also receives the much-needed improvement over earlier models in terms of accuracy. Its dotted-texture also provides a better feel and grip while navigating. The real kill-joy for us was that the multi-touch scrolling option, available on many previous Eee PC models, has been replaced with the traditional side-scrolling mechanism.

On the inside, we find Intel's new Atom N280 processor that has a 60 MHz speed bump over the N270s fitted in most of the models. We concluded from our tests that the N280 boosts performance by a slight margin. The speed-up is not really noticeable when using typical apps. Also, all the Eee PCs, including this one, support the latest Wi-Fi 802.11n standard, which is much appreciated.

The built-in battery raked out a nearly three-and-a-half hour battery life - this is good for such a slim device. Thus, under normal usage, it should give you more than four hours of juice. The web cam belted out decent quality but not exactly with a smooth frame-

rate. The Rs. 27,000 price tag is the premium you'll have to pay for this sleek beauty. We think its somewhat overpriced, but if the price were to drop to Rs. 25k or less, that would make it a worthwhile buy.

Asus Eee PC 1005HA Well-priced workhorse

- Good keyboard, Very good battery life, Wi-Fi 802.11n support, Well priced.
- Screen brightness a bit low.

On the heels of the slim 'n' sexy 1008HA is its slightly chubby sibling, the 1005HA. Its top shares the same shell-like look of its thinner cousin. It may not be very thin, but it is certainly sleeker and attractive compared to earlier iterations of the Eee PC. The 1005HA has a non-glossy base, unlike the fully-glossy body of the 1008HA. Other than that, both the models are the same internally.

Citing one of the few differences between the two, the



Asus Eee PC 1005HA

1005HA has a removable 6-cell battery that delivers a really good battery life; close to six hours in our stress-test. Thus, this model can survive close to an eight-hour working-day without a charge - if you're not going to do resource-intensive work. Amongst the bundle of apps that Asus packed with this model, we liked the Parental Control and the Font Resizer.

Other than the non-removable battery, the 1005HA also shares the cons

that we've mentioned in the 1008HA write-up above. The web cam performs similarly to the 1008HA model. The Wi-Fi performance in general on all Eee PC models was average using 802.11g mode. When testing with the 802.11n mode using a compatible router, we saw that the performance jump was about 15-20 per cent over 802.11g. The Eee PC 1005HA is priced quite reasonably at Rs. 21,500. This model will give you pretty much everything from the 1008HA model for Rs. 6500 less. So, if you want a decent netbook and can sacrifice the ultra-thin measurement of the 1008HA, this is the model you should consider.

Zenith Premium Z-book Cheap, in every sense of the term

- Good quality bright screen, sturdy build, cheap price.
- Average keyboard and touchpad usability, measly battery life.

The Zenith Z-book has a slightly small footprint and isn't really eye-candy compared to the others in our test. The device feels quite compact to hold and has quite a solid feel to it. The screen hinge offered more-than-adequate resistance

Opening this netbook reveals a very bright screen. We tried watching a few 720p hi-def videos on it and realised that the screen delivered quite admirably. The contrast-ratio, as seen by our tests, was also very high. But this is where praise for the Z-book ends. The keyboard is cramped compared to the well spaced ones on other models. The only good thing about it is that

it has media playback shortcuts on its function keys. Even the touch-pad left-and-right click buttons are flimsy. The Z-book doesn't impress as such in the performance figures. The battery died out after 1.5 hours. It should give

approximately 2-2.5 hours of time under normal usage; this is quite a measly performance for a netbook. The web camera's output was quite grainy and dark and the frame-rate was also pretty average.

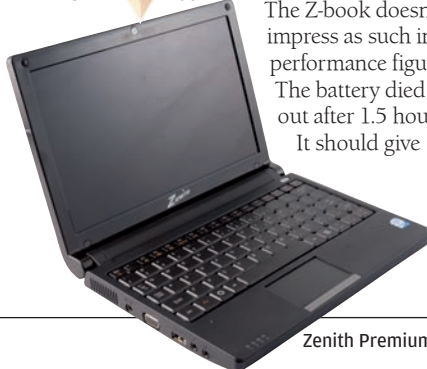
Other than the surprisingly-good screen and a decent build, there is nothing about the Z-book that we would write home about. It is by far the cheapest netbook we've seen at just Rs. 16,500. That's almost 20 per cent cheaper than the next cheapest netbook. For the price, you compromise a bit on the usability and performance but it's still a very usable piece of hardware.

Asus Eee PC 1101HA Breaking the 10-inch barrier

- 11.1-inch screen size, excellent battery life, comparatively sleek, comfortable keyboard.
- Screen brightness a bit low, under-powered processor.

The first Eee PC to break the 10-inch screen barrier, the 1101HA has a slightly larger footprint in order to accommodate the 11.6-inch, 1366x768 pixel screen. It has kept its thickness under check, and the overall machine is quite portable. Sharing the Seashell-branded appearance of the family, the cool-looking white model that we received reminded us of the older Macbooks.

The "HD" resolution display has a 16:9 aspect ratio; great for watching movies without those black borders. A short-length 720p test video looked pretty good and ran quite smoothly. Although we felt that the screen brightness was not up to the mark. The display wasn't vibrant enough compared to some others in our test. But for typical work such as internet surfing and document editing, it's quite sufficient. The keyboard is well spaced and easy to type on. The touch-pad is similar to the 1005HA and 1008HA model. This model comes with a low-power Atom Z520 processor running at 1.33 GHz. From the synthetic tests, it is clear that the 1101HA's performance is even lower than the low-scoring



Zenith Premium Z-book